operative handling the case thought that it was a brilliant offer, but his senior in Delhi did not respond. That outlaw is now an influential figure. If he had been recruited, he might have provided a number of critical intelligence inputs on terror groups, the ISI and the secrets of the Pakistani governments. There is simply no substitute for a ready-to-be-launched asset.

Despite certain failures, R&AW operations have helped safeguard the country's interests. As the first line of defence against overseas threats, the agency continues to provide intelligence to the prime minister and various security agencies, speaking truth to power. At the same time, the intelligence agency requires a clear political direction with zero interference if it is to maintain its neutrality, speed and efficiency.

NOTES

1. Bloodbath in Bangladesh

l. R&AW U.O. Note No. 6/BD/75(6)-VI. Bangladesh Assessment by Deputy Director A.K. Verma.

2. R&AW U.O. Note No. 6/BD/75 (12) Bangladesh scale of activity, N.F. Suntook.

3. Ministry of External Affairs, 26/TS/ JS (PP)/75. Assistance to resistance groups and anti-government forces in Bangladesh.

4. High Commissioner to Bangladesh, Letter No. DAC/102/1/75. HC Foreign influence, political parties and political trends.